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Revelation: Lacan and the Ten Commandments

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Whereas in Jewish and Christian theology, "Creation" refers to God's primal relation to all of humanity and indeed to the world as a whole, "Revelation" refers to the imposition of God's will as law, in-scription, and pre-scription on a particular people. The core of this Revelation is the Ten Commandments, a text at once so relentlessly commonplace and so morally exhausting that it hardly seems to bear, let alone elicit, re-reading. For many of us, it is filed away in the furthest reaches of our learning, rendered inaccessible to higher thought by the very primitiveness of its first acquisition. The Decalogue is so close to us that it is invisible, so familiar that it is largely forgotten, and so (apparently) simple that it is most frequently recollected in the form of the joke and the error, the stutter and the laugh.

> God spoke all these words, saying, I the Lord \[YHVH\] am your God who brought you out of the land of Egypt.
3). [~2]

In their commentaries, the rabbis linked the sublimity of God's name ' the unspeakable Tetragrammaton

> I must leave to one side the huge questions posed by the promulgation of these commandments to the Israelites at Sinai. The name of God, Asher-Ehyeh_\]. It is, in effect, necessary not to draw the text in the direction of Greek metaphysics.

Lacan insists on the fundamental untranslatability between the Hebrew name of God and the Greek name of God.

> Remember the sabbath day and keep it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but on the seventh day you shall rest.
11)

The commandment calls up the cacophony of human activity -- sons and daughters, slaves and cats, and the domestic activity that completes the six days of Creation in Genesis. If the world was "finished" on the sixth day, the Sabbath

> I leave aside the question of rest on the sabbath day. But I believe that that extraordinary injunction to cease all work for one day a week, Lacan notes, ran counter to the needs of the modern

The injunction to cease all work for one day a week, Lacan notes, ran counter to the needs of the modern economy lodged at the heart of the West's cultural, philosophical, and monetary economies.

> It begins at the moment when the subject poses the question of that good he had unconsciously repressed.
76)

One might think that the Tenth Commandment is designed to discipline desire, reinforcing the prohibition of the incestuous, deployed, re-initiated, re-constructed ' _sublimated_ -- in the subject's relationships to all other

> I am going to give you a proof that is to my mind nevertheless valid. It concerns Proudhon's theory of the right of property.

The discourse of rights is founded on the privacy and self-possession of the person; the spectral subject of the psychoanalytic detector offends the liberal subject because it would trespass on the inalienability of the inner

formations of dreams, poetry, and social arrangements, in every act of speech. But what we tra
 ability to the estimate fragment of the real that the subject is called to confront ("the pursu

- Introduction - Julia Reinhard Lupton, University of California Irvine.
- Creation - Richard Halpern, University of California Berkeley.
- Redemption - Gregg Lambert, Syracuse University.

Notes

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[^1] Levinas, "Revelation in the Jewish Tradition," in *The Levinas Reader*, ed. Sean Hand (Cambridge: Blackwell) 194.

[^2] For all citations from The Bible, see Nahum H. Sarna (ed.) *The JPS Torah and Commentary*, 5 vols. (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1989).

¹ Rashi. *Chumash with Rashi*, vol. 2, ed. A. M. Silbermann (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1934), 102; Maimonides cited in S.Y. Agnon, *Present at Sinai: The Giving of the Law*, trans. Michael

¹Yet, it is precisely because of the Decalogue's deadening proximity to our earliest memories of knowledge itself in its condition as pure inscription and brute *techne* that it calls for a work of rereading, of active de-familiarization and re-familiarization. Such a work was initiated by Jacques Lacan in his seminar on the ethics of psychoanalysis. In his brief but astute commentary, Lacan suggests that the Decalogue stages the alienation of the subject by a singular signifier, installs that same subject within the rule of speech at the expense of the imaginary, and organizes the subject's desire in relation to the jouissance of the neighbor. Levinas wrote of Revelation that "Its word comes from elsewhere, from outside, and, at the same time, lives within the person receiving it."[^1] This essay attempts to disclose the logic that places revelation in its heteronomous, scriptural, and arbitrary character at the heart of Western subjectivity and its psychoanalytic interpretation, opening it to ethical reclamation in the present moment.

Swirsky (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1994), 206; *Midrash Rabbah*, vol. 3, trans. H. Freedman (London: Soncino Press, 1983), 336.

² Jacques Lacan, *Le séminaire, livre VII: L'éthique de la psychanalyse, 1959-60*, established by Jacques-Alain Miller (Paris: Seuil, 1986); trans. by Dennis Porter as *The Seminar of Jacques Lacan, Book VII: The Ethics of Psychoanalysis, 1959-1960* (NY: Norton, 1986), 81.

³ For midrashim on Roman reactions to the Jewish Sabbath, see Hayim Nahman Bialik and Hana Ravnitzky Yehoshua, eds. *The Book of Legends: Sefer Ha-Aggadah: Legends from the Talmud and Midrash*, trans. William G. Braude (New York: Schocken Books, 1992), 250 and 380.

⁴ Philo of Alexandria, a Hellenistic Jew responding to the challenges of philosophy and of Greco-Roman values, defends the Sabbath on utilitarian grounds. See *The Special Laws*, vol. 2 of *The Works of Philo*, trans. C. D. Yonge (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson Pubs., 1993), 60.

⁵ Franz Rosenzweig, *The Star of Redemption*, trans. from the Second Edition of 1930 by William W. Hallo (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1985), 383.

⁶ Walter Benjamin, *Illuminations*, ed. Hannah Arendt, trans. Harry Zohn (New York: Schocken Books, 1969), 264.

⁷ Jacques Lacan, *The Seminar Book XX: Encore; On Feminine Sexuality and the Limits of Love and Knowledge, 1972-73*, established by Jacques-Alain Miller, trans. Bruce Fink (New York: Norton, 1998), 6.

²The first tablet of the Decalogue concerns man's relation to *God's name* in its radical singularity and unpronounceability:

³In the election of the Israelites as God's people, the proper name YHWH functions as the primary signifier Lacan will call S1, the signifier without signified that anchors the subject within a particular constellation of the symbolic order through a cataclysmic encounter with language in its materiality, as sheer command, as pure revelation without rhyme or reason. The letters of the Tetragrammaton suggest the verb of being, and thus promise a semantic content that would wed it to ontology, yet the conventions surrounding its articulation sustain the Name as a talismanic set of letters that cannot be translated into any definitive etymology or meaning.

⁴The second commandment, against idolatry, links this primary signifier to the chain of all other signifiers in the act of barring the realm of the image. In Lacan's formulation, in the prohibition against idolatry, "the elimination of the function of the imaginary presents itself ... as the principle of the relation to the symbolic ... that is to say, to speech" (81). The third commandment, "You shall not take the name of the Lord your God in vain" (Ex. 20:7), sequesters the name in its status as primary signifier, maintaining the force of its primal repression: keeping it sacred, but also *keeping it away*, preventing its creative-destructive power from bleeding into the language of the everyday. Together, these three initial commandments establish the singularity of God's name in relation to the plurality of the signifying chain.

⁵The Fourth Commandment, which institutes the Sabbath, turns to the world of human activity as regulated by the Name of God:

⁶Lacan captures the scandal of the Sabbath in a suggestive "aside" that addresses the function of the Sabbath as itself a "setting-aside," a ritualized intermission in the ordinary flow of social intercourse:

⁷The Fourth Commandment aligns the lacuna in the temporal sequence marked by the seventh day with the place held by God's unspeakable name in the procession of signifiers. Out of the string of days, one day is marked off as a break in time: the Sabbath. Out of the string of signifiers, one is held in abeyance: the name of God. The subject of religion falls out of the petty pace of tomorrow and tomorrow and tomorrow, signifying in the nothing of that suspension the possibility of a subject. Lacan's famous dictum, "a signifier represents the subject for another signifier," as mathematized in the Master's Discourse, describes this creation of the subject out of the *nihil* that interrupts the symbolic circuit of alienation. Such a subject is the crown of creation *ex nihilo*, insofar as both the subject and creation are defined by a *nihil* or Nothing, cut off from their natural cycles by the de-naturing of time imposed by the Sabbath.